

South Korea Industrials: Defense and Robotics: Takeaways from US marketing

During our US marketing trip (New York & Boston) last week, investor discussions focused on 2H catalysts and candidates that could spark broader sector strength, especially given Korea's heavy skew toward memory names. In this context, the Korea Defense and Robotics sectors were heavily discussed. We believe Korea Defense and Robotics sectors are poised to see decent performance in 2H.

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Korea Defense

Korean defense drew strong investor interest, driven by: 1) significant 2Q underperformance, 2) low correlation with AI within Industrials, and 3) accelerating order momentum. This combination positions the sector as an attractive option to diversify the portfolio while offering both relative value and upcoming catalysts.

We attribute the 2Q underperformance to three factors: 1) stagnant order development, 2) market skew toward memory, and 3) share price weakness among global defense peers. However, with order momentum expected to build in 2H (link to latest [note](#)), an expanding Western European TAM, and compressed multiples that discount these catalysts, we expect Korean defense to regain momentum in 2H26.

We believe key pivotal developments for the Korea Defense sector that occurred in the past month are as follows:

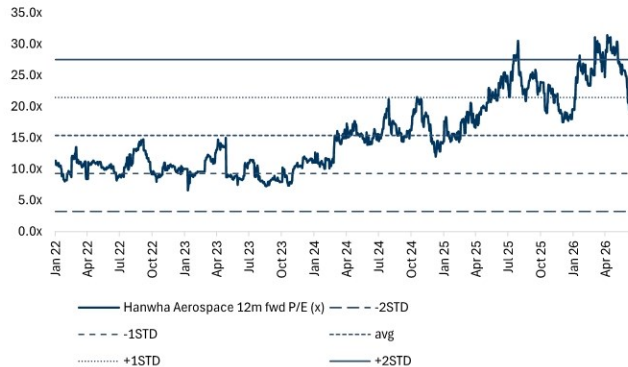
- 1) Switzerland exploring Korean air defense: Switzerland is considering Korean air defense systems due to delay in Patriot deliveries ([link](#))
- 2) Spain finalizing K9 order: Spain is likely to finalize its K9 (SpH) order with Hanwha Aerospace ([link](#))
- 3) LIG D&A and Rheinmetall MOU: LIG D&A and Rheinmetall signed an MOU for air defense missiles ([link](#))
- 4) Thales and Hanwha Aerospace MOU: Thales and Hanwha Aerospace signed an MOU for Chunmoo guided missiles ([link](#)).
- 5) Peru election concluded: Peru's presidential election is complete ([link](#)).

These developments over the past month indicate that key Western European countries are increasingly relying on Korean companies for faster execution. Additionally, previous order bottlenecks for Rotem in Iraq and Peru, which stemmed from political uncertainty, are also easing.

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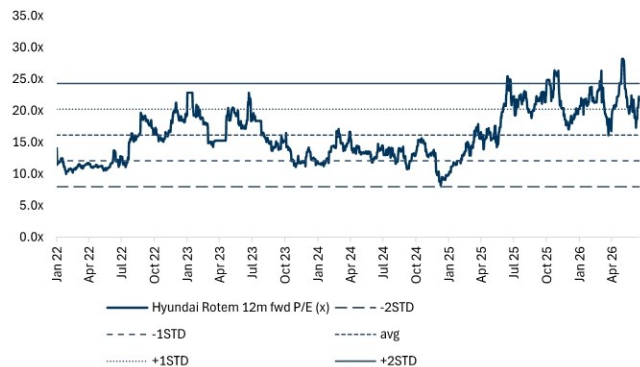
Hence we believe the Korea Defense sector is well positioned to show some signs of revival in 2H, especially with valuations levels now quite attractive respective to earnings profiles ([Exhibit 1](#) - [Exhibit 4](#)).

Exhibit 1: Hanwha Aerospace: 12m fwd P/E



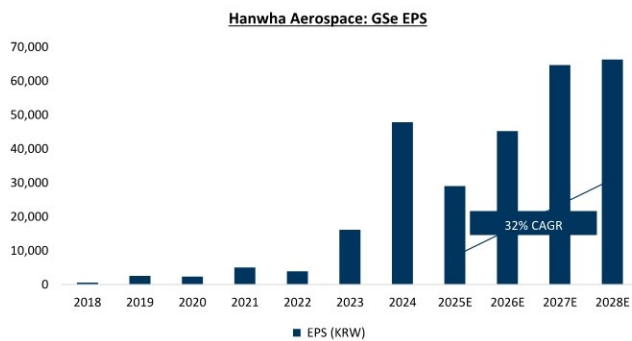
Source: Bloomberg, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: Hyundai Rotem: 12m fwd P/E



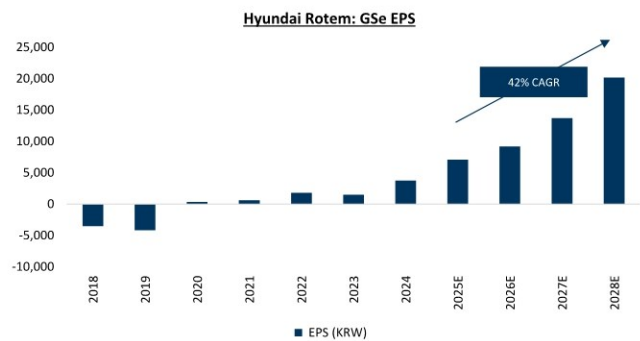
Source: Bloomberg, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: Hanwha Aerospace: GSe EPS



Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Hyundai Rotem: GSe EPS

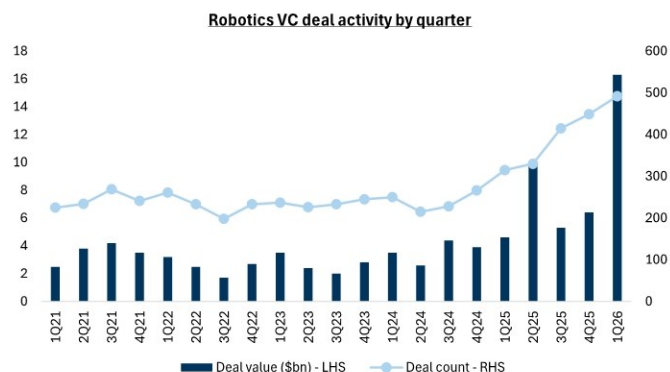


Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Korea Robotics

Investors also showed strong interest in the Korean robotics sector. While most believe humanoid adoption will take time, there was broad consensus that the sector is poised for eventual, significant growth. This interest can also be underscored by [Exhibit 5](#) below, which shows robotics investments reaching an all-time high.

Exhibit 5: Recent robotics VC deal activity underscores interests in the robotics sector



Source: Pitchbook

While investors frequently question if it is too early to build exposure to long-duration robotics stocks, we emphasize that robotics has become a top global policy priority, and that it is a race—a core thesis of our recent Korea Robotics initiation [piece](#).

In fact we are seeing many signs that government support is accelerating globally:

South Korea: The Ministry of Science and ICT are establishing robot data training centers with government funding slated for next year ([link](#)) while President Lee is convening major robotics CEOs for a roundtable on June 29th ([link](#)).

United States: Commerce Secretary Lutnick recently declared robotics “the next battleground in technological competition” framing China’s state-backed industry as a national security threat ([link](#)).

Technological standardization is also easing commercialization barriers. Nvidia’s launch of [Halos](#), an open robotics safety system, should help industry participants standardize and accelerate safety certifications for humanoids.

We believe Korean companies offer a wide set of robotics related themes such as key enablers of mass production for ex-China companies along with real humanoid adoption. Some of the key ideas include Hyundai Motor Group names (Hyundai Mobis as one of the key ideas), Auto-parts names (HL Mando) and pure robotics name (Robotis).

Finally, history shows that AI applications utilizing reinforcement learning consistently deliver exponential capability breakthroughs, as seen in LLMs ([Exhibit 6](#)). We believe robotics is poised for a similar trajectory or eventually have its breakthrough moment, making early exposure highly compelling. Sector mindshare is also expanding globally, illustrated by recent news reports ([link](#)).

Exhibit 6: How long a task AI can do (at 50% success rate) is growing exponentially

Each dot is a frontier AI model



Source: METR

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Hanwha Aerospace

Our 12-month target price of W1,810,000 is based on a target P/E multiple of 28.0x applied to 2027E EPS. Key risks include: 1) lower-than-expected order wins, 2) lower-than-expected OPM from overseas production, 3) lower-than-expected demand from NATO's Eastern Flank and MENA countries, 4) regional geopolitical developments resulting in shift in focus to domestic procurement, and 5) stronger KRW against the USD.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Hyundai Rotem

Our 12-month target price of W280,000 is based on a target P/E multiple of 20.8x applied to 2027E EPS. Key risks include: 1) lower-than-expected order wins, 2) lower-than-expected OPM from overseas production, 3) lower-than-expected demand from NATO's Eastern Flank and MENA countries, 4) regional geopolitical developments resulting in shift in focus to domestic procurement, and 5) stronger KRW against the USD.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Hyundai Mobis

We are Buy-rated. Our 12-month target price of W710,000 is based on a target P/E multiple of 15.0x applied to 2035E EPS discounted back to June 2027.

Downside risks: 1) Cost inflation-related margin pressure along with production disruption from the fire in the India plant 2) Slower-than-expected execution in terms of Boston Dynamics or HMG autonomous driving push.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - HL Mando

We are Buy-rated. Our 12-month target price of W109,000 is based on a target P/E multiple of 15.0x applied to 2035E EPS discounted back to June 2027.

We see four downside risks: 1) No humanoid actuator order by the end of 2027, 2) Higher Capex in North America expected in the next few years, hence, end-demand is key for margins, 3) Stagnant ADAS business, 4) Cost inflation.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Robotis

We are Buy rated. Our 12-month target price of W630,000 is based on a target P/E multiple of 60.0x applied to 2035E EPS discounted back to June 2027.

We see three downside risks: 1) Execution risks due to slower progress at the Uzbekistan facility, 2) No major orders for humanoid actuators in 2027/2028, and 3) Aggressive pricing on key products leading to dilution in margins and earnings.

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